

Ronald Araujo and Jose Maria Gimenez, Bielsa's redemption arc may ultimately depend on whether he can turn Uruguay's control and defensive solidity into goals.

Meanwhile, Saudi Arabia, the other team in the group, comes into the World Cup in a very different shape than the last one. The Asian powerhouse had stunned eventual champion Argentina in the group stages, with coach Hervé Renard making headlines with his half-time speech.

Renard has been shown the door, and the appointment of a new coach, Georgios Donis, just months before the World Cup despite his lack of international coaching experience, pushes Saudi Arabia into unfamiliar territory. Several players of the 2022 squad, though, remain, with Salem Al-Dawsari expected to control the midfield, while Firas Al-Buraikan is likely to lead the attack.

The fact that the Green Falcons have won just once in the last seven games will also dent their morale as they look to beat the odds to progress beyond the group stages of the World Cup for the first time since 1994.



Federico Valverde (Uruguay)

Federico Valverde has honed his talent from Luka Modric and chiselled himself to be omnipresent on the field. Be it progressive carries or tracking back, Valverde will be the linchpin of Uruguay's midfield. With nine goals and 12 assists in the recently concluded season, Valverde will be a perpetual threat in and around the box.



Salem Al-Dawsari (Saudi Arabia)

When Saudi Arabia humbled Argentina, it was Salem Al-Dawsari who struck the winner. The two-time AFC Player of the Year continues to be one of the best players in his squad and, with 10 goals and 10 assists for Al Ahli this season, the 34-year-old will look to give his best shot in his potential last World Cup.

SQUADS

Spain

Goalkeepers: Unai Simón, David Raya, Joan García

Defenders: Marc Cucurella, Alejandro Grimaldo, Pau Cubarsí, Aymeric Laporte, Marc Pubill, Eric García, Marcos Llorente, Pedro Porro

Midfielders: Pedri, Fabián Ruiz, Martín Zubimendi, Gavi, Rodrigo Hernández, Álex Baena, Mikel Merino

Forwards: Dani Olmo, Mikel Oyarzabal, Nico Williams, Jeremy Pino, Ferran Torres, Borja Iglesias, Víctor Muñoz, Lamine Yamal

Cape Verde

Goalkeepers: Carlos dos Santos, Marcio Rosa, Vozinha

Defenders: Sidney Cabral, Diney Borges, Logan Costa, Roberto Lopes, Steven Moreira, Wagner Pina, Kelvin Pires, Stopira

Midfielders: Telmo Arcanjo, Deroy Duarte, Laros Duarte, Joao Paulo Fernandes, Jamiro Monteiro, Kevin Pina, Yannick Semedo

Forwards: Gilson Benchimol, Jovane Cabral, Dailon Livramento, Ryan Mendes, Nuno da Costa, Garry Rodrigues, Willy Semedo, Helio Varela

Uruguay

Goalkeepers: Sergio Rochet, Fernando Muslera, Santiago Mele

Defenders: Guillermo Varela, Ronald Araújo, José María Giménez, Santiago Bueno, Sebastián Caceres, Mathías Olivera, Joaquín Piquerez, Matías Viña

Midfielders: Manuel Ugarte, Emiliano Martínez, Rodrigo Bentancur, Federico Valverde, Agustín Canobbio, Juan Manuel Sanabria, Giorgian de Arrascaeta, Nicolás de la Cruz, Rodrigo Zalazar, Facundo Pellistri, Maximiliano Araújo, Brian Rodríguez

Forwards: Rodrigo Aguirre, Federico Viñas, Darwin Núñez

Saudi Arabia

Goalkeepers: Ahmed Al Kassar, Mohammed Al Owais, Nawaf Al Aqidi

Defenders: Saud Abdulhamid, Mohammed Abu Al Shamat, Moteb Al Harbi, Abdulelah Al Amri, Nawaf Boushal, Hassan Kadesh, Ali Lajami, Ali Majrashi, Hassan Tambakti, Jehad Thakri

Midfielders: Nasser Al Dawsari, Alaa Al Hajji, Ziyad Al Johani, Musab Al Juwayr, Abdullah Al Khaibari, Mohammed Kanno, Sultan Mandash, Ayman Yahya, Khalid Al-Ghannam

Forwards: Feras Al Brikan, Salem Al Dawsari, Abdullah Al Hamdan, Saleh Al Shehri